

“The Fear of the Lord is Wisdom”? A Consideration of Job 28 as a Sarcastic Response to the Wisdom Tradition*

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In its present context, the so-called Wisdom Poem in Job 28 is attributed to Job. However, as is well attested, the chapter stands apart in style and vocabulary from the rest of the Book of Job. As such, Job 28 has been treated variously by interpreters, understanding the chapter as an independent composition, a parenthetical insertion by the author of the book, or misplaced words of Elihu. Some are satisfied with the canonical arrangement and attribute the chapter to the words of Job. Others are not persuaded by any of the options. One of the issues that complicates interpretation is the function of כִּי at the head of the chapter. It has been construed as an emphatic particle, as evidence that the chapter is misplaced, or that it introduces a quotation from a lost ancient Israelite source. This essay will examine another function of כִּי, in which it introduces direct speech. If כִּי in Job 28 functions in this manner, then we should understand the chapter as coming from the mouth of Job, but not as the words of Job. Rather, Job is understood as citing a supposedly well-known wisdom poem, although he disagrees with its content. In contrast to the assertions of the poem, even though Job turned away from evil (סָר מִרָע 1:1, 8; 2:3), evil did not turn away (מָרַע 28:28) from him, and his fear of Yahweh did not lead to understanding. Thus, this paper argues that in Job 28 Job sarcastically recites a poem espousing traditional wisdom to emphasize the inadequacy of the tradition.

INTRODUCTION

Interpreters are near unanimous in their agreement that Job 28, the so-called Wisdom Poem, is distinctly different from the rest of the dialogue portion of the Book of Job. The chapter contains the only instances of arthrous הַחֲכָמָה (28:12, 20), the only occurrence of אֲדָנִי (28:28), and the unique lexeme סָגוֹר (“refined gold”; 28:15) in the entire book.¹ But beyond mere vocabulary, the content and

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1. Hebrew סָגוֹר has been translated variously as gold (ESV, NAB, NET, NJPS, NRSVue), finest gold

character of chapter 28 make it “an anomaly in its present position.”² However, as noted, interpreters are less than unanimous as to why Job 28 is so vastly distinct from its surrounding chapters.

In light of these discrepancies and anomalies, interpreters have understood Job 28 variously, which I will discuss in some detail below. There are good reasons for considering each of these positions, and each argument has received various degrees of acceptance. Yet there are also valid reasons why none has achieved consensus. In this essay I will attempt to add an alternative suggestion for the placement and purpose of Job 28 that builds on several separate, but related arguments: (1) the literary cohesion of Job 26–31, especially with respect to the intrusion at 27:1 and 29:1 of the discourse formula *ויען... ויאמר*; (2) the interpretation of the particle *כי* as a rhetorical marker identifying the introduction of third-party direct speech; (3) the presence of linguistic and rhetorical markers within the chapter signaling content that is external to the speaker; (4) sarcasm as an observed feature in the Book of Job; and (5) modern socio-linguistic studies on sarcasm detection. Following this line of argument, I suggest that in chapter 28 Job sarcastically recites a poem expressing traditional wisdom to underscore the inadequacy of the tradition.

FIVE VIEWS ON THE SPEAKER IN JOB 28

There are at least five major views which attempt to explain the position and function of Job 28.³

Original Composition

The most prominent view is that Job 28 is an original composition with various interpretations regarding its origin. John Gray suggests it may have been composed by someone in the same circle as the author of the book itself, or

(NIV), and pure gold (NASB). Edward L. Greenstein, *Job: A New Translation* (New Haven, CT: Yale, 2019), renders it “bullion” (p. 163). Elsewhere in the MT the root is only related to precious metals in temple contexts as a Qal passive participle and stands in the attributive position with *זהב* (1 Kgs 6:20, 21; 7:49, 50; 10:21; 2 Chr 4:20, 22; 9:20), modifying the type of gold out of which temple artifacts are crafted. Etymologically, the word derives from the root **sgr*, to shut or close. The Akkadian cognate *sakru* frequently modifies or is in a synonymous position to *ḫarāṣu*, “gold.” *The Assyrian Dictionary of the Oriental Institute of the University of Chicago* 15 (S), 81.

2. James K. Aitken, “Lexical Semantics and the Cultural Context of Knowledge in Job 28, Illustrated by the Meaning of *ḥāqar*,” in *Job 28: Cognition in Context*, ed. Ellen van Wolde. Biblical Interpretation 64 (Leiden: Brill, 2003), 119–37, esp. 121.
3. For a thorough, though somewhat dated, review of the literature, see Scott C. Jones, *Rumors of Wisdom: Job 28 as Poetry*. Beihefte zur Zeitschrift für die alttestamentliche Wissenschaft 398 (Berlin: Walter de Gruyter, 2009), 5–17.

that it is perhaps “an independent composition by the author of the Book of Job himself, justly valued by his circle and included in the Book in appreciation of the master.”⁴ For reasons of style, Francis Andersen, Georg Fohrer, John Hartley, and Marvin Pope view the poem as an independent composition.⁵ Marvin Pope refers to the poem as extraneous, but extols the poem as “one of the finest in the Old Testament.”⁶ According to James Crenshaw, Job 28 was a later composition inserted into its present location as “a kind of interlude” that ties it back to Job 1:1.⁷ August Konkel simply notes the chapter “is perfectly comprehensible as an independent composition.”⁸ Carol Newsom, offering a more nuanced approach to this position, argues throughout her work that Job is a polyphonic text representing various voices and genres. For Newsom, chapter 28 “introduces a recognizably new voice, different from either the voice of the prose tale narration or from the characters who speak in the wisdom dialogue.” In short, it is “one voice among others” and “need not be identified as the author’s own perspective, however, any more than the voice of the narrator, the voice of Job, or any other might be.”⁹

Parenthetical Insertion

Another view is that Job 28 is a parenthetical insertion by the author of the book. According to Robert Gordis, chapter 28 is lyrical poem written by the book’s author in his youth. It anticipates the divine speeches in chapters 38–41 and “was probably preserved with the other writings of the poet by his early readers and admirers and included by a copyist with the book of Job.”¹⁰ In his view, the author of the book did not include the chapter in his version of the

4. John Gray, *The Book of Job*. Text of the Hebrew Bible 1 (Sheffield: Sheffield Phoenix, 2010; repr. 2015), 340.
5. Francis I. Andersen, *Job: An Introduction and Commentary*. Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries 13 (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1976), 223; Georg Fohrer, *Studien zum Buche Hiob* (Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus Gerd Mohn, 1963), 392; John E. Hartley, *The Book of Job*. New International Commentary of the Old Testament (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 373; Marvin H. Pope, *Job: A New Translation with Introduction and Commentary*. Anchor Bible 15 (New York: Doubleday, 1965; repr. 1983), xxvii.
6. Pope, *Job*, xxvii.
7. James L. Crenshaw, *Reading Job: A Literary and Theological Commentary* (Macon, GA: Smyth & Helwys, 2011), 122. See also L. Alonso Schökel and Sicre Díaz, *Job: Commentario Teológico y Literario*. Nueva Biblia Española (Madrid: Cristiandad), 389.
8. August H. Konkel, *Job*. Cornerstone Biblical Commentary (Carol Stream, IL: Tyndale House, 2006), 171.
9. Carol A. Newsom, *The Book of Job: A Contest of Moral Imaginations* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003), 170.
10. Robert Gordis, *The Book of Job: Commentary, New Translation, Special Studies* (New York: Jewish Theological Seminary of America, 1978; repr. 2011), 298.

book. It was only later included “by scribal accident.”¹¹ Although it is out of place in its current location, it does serve “as a ‘musical interlude’ between the debate and Job’s final soliloquy.”¹² For John Walton, chapter 28 is an interjection by the narrator “that serves as a pivot for the book and a transition from the dialogues to the discourses.”¹³ Lindsay Wilson understands Job 28 “as an appropriate reflection by the author or editor at the crucial time when the dialogue has broken down.”¹⁴

Misplaced Words of Elihu

A third view is that Job 28 is best understood as misplaced words of Elihu. According to David Clines, the chapter continues Elihu’s theme concerning how God communicates with humanity. It was originally situated at the conclusion of Elihu’s speeches and would have followed immediately after chapter 37, which concludes:

Therefore mortals fear him;
and the wise in heart are afraid of him. (37:24)¹⁵

For Clines, chapter 28 continues this theme, but from the perspective of humanity, “asking how they are to attain that wisdom, and what shape that wisdom will have for them.”¹⁶ Edward Greenstein likewise sees chapter 28 as a continuation of chapter 37. Whereas Job 37 sets its sights on God’s created world in the upper realm, Job 28 turns its attention to God’s created world in the lower realm – the earth, the netherworld, and the cosmic sea.¹⁷ N.H. Tur-Sinai also sees chapter 28 as misplaced, but not as part of Elihu’s speech. He situates it after Job 42:3 as an appropriate response to the divine speeches, leading to the conclusion that wisdom can only be found with God, not with humans.¹⁸

11. Robert Gordis, *The Book of Job and Man: A Study of Job* (Chicago, IL & London: University of Chicago Press, 1965), 102.

12. Gordis, *Book of Job*, 298.

13. John H. Walton, *Job*. The NIV Application Commentary (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2012), 29.

14. Lindsay Wilson, *Job*. The Two Horizons Old Testament Commentary (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2015), 134.

15. David J.A. Clines, *Job 21–37*. Word Biblical Commentary 18A (Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2006), 809.

16. Clines, *Job 21–37*, 907.

17. Edward L. Greenstein, “The Poem in Job 28 in Its Conceptual and Literary Contexts,” in *Job 28: Cognition in Context*. Biblical Interpretations Series 64, ed. Ellen van Wolde (Leiden: Brill, 2003), 253–80, esp. 267–72; *idem*, *Job: A New Translation* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2019), 160–61. Consequently, it is worth noting that Greenstein’s argument closely aligns with Jones, *Rumors of Wisdom*, in which Job 28 does not refer to mining, but to land beyond the cosmic sea, a region beyond the reach of mortals.

18. N.H. Tur-Sinai, *The Book of Job: A New Commentary* (Jerusalem: Kiryath Sepher, 1957), 395.

Words of Job

Despite the stylistic differences and various incongruities, a significant number of interpreters attribute chapter 28 to Job, the stated speaker of chapters 26–27 and 29–31.¹⁹ For Robert Alden, the justification for this view is based on his *a priori* commitment to the inspiration of Scripture.²⁰ Others, like Edwin Good, are simply resigned to the fact that the chapter is attributed to Job in its canonical context, whether it deserves to be there or not.²¹ Mostly, however, those in this camp see an intentionality in the text's shift in style that serves a rhetorical function. Alison Lo sees in Job 28 an authentic expression of the human emotional state in the midst of suffering.²² Claire Egan's 2002 dissertation makes an argument for the literary unity of Job 24–28.²³ For Kathleen O'Connor, "the chapter serves as a theological comment on the book itself, voiced by its principal character Job. It is as if he has temporarily stepped aside from the debate to comment on it."²⁴ Gerald Janzen sees in chapter 28 a contrite Job who confesses his own failure in finding wisdom.²⁵

Undecided

Finally, some interpreters are either agnostic on the topic or unpersuaded by any of the available options.²⁶ For these interpreters the evidence is insufficient to support any particular conclusion.

19. In addition to those cited below, see also Brevard S. Childs, *Introduction to the Old Testament as Scripture* (London: SCM, 1979), 542; Moshe Greenberg, "Job," in *The Literary Guide to the Bible*, ed. R. Alter and F. Kermode (Cambridge, MA: Belknap, 1987): 283–304, esp. 294; and Gerald Henry Wilson, *Job*. New International Bible Commentary (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2007), 300.
20. Robert L. Alden, *Job: An Exegetical and Theological Exposition of Holy Scripture*. The New American Commentary 11 (Nashville, TN: Broadman & Holman, 1993), 269.
21. Edwin M. Good, *In Turns of Tempest: A Reading of Job with Translation* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1990), 290.
22. Allison Lo, *Job 28 as Rhetoric: An Analysis of Job 28 in the Context of Job 22–31*. VTSup 97 (Leiden: Brill, 2003). See also Tremper Longman III, *Job*. Baker Commentary on the Old Testament Wisdom and Psalms (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2012), 329.
23. Claire Egan, "The Integrity of Job: A Contextual Study of Job Chapters 24–28." PhD diss., Birmingham University, 2002.
24. Kathleen O'Connor, *Job*. New Collegeville Bible Commentary 19 (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 2012), 64.
25. J. Gerald Janzen, *Job*. Interpretation: A Bible Commentary for Teaching and Preaching (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1985; repr. 2012), 191.
26. Samuel L. Balentine, *Job*. Smyth & Helwys Commentary (Macon, GA: Smyth & Helwys, 2006), 417; Steven Chase, *Job*. Belief: A Theological Commentary on the Bible (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2013), 209; James A. Wharton, *Job*. Westminster Bible Companion (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1999), 113–14.

JOB NOT THE SPEAKER IN JOB 28

Despite the efforts of some to assign chapter 28 to Job himself, it is widely recognized that this chapter is an intrusion. According to Hartley, “its abstract, reflective tone does not match well any of the speakers.”²⁷ Kathleen O’Connor summarizes the challenges nicely.

The problems of this chapter become immediately apparent to any careful reader. Job changes the subject from his suffering and the fate of the wicked in the previous speeches to the search for wisdom. The tone of the passage changes, too, from discontent to tranquility. It ends with a renewal of traditional wisdom embraced by the book’s prologue where “the fear of the Lord is wisdom.” (28:28; cf. 1:1, 8; 2:3)²⁸

Thus, whenever attempts are made to align the chapter with the character Job, concessions must inevitably be made by appealing to the complexity and multi-dimensionality of literary characters, or to the psychological effects associated with individuals who have endured trauma. Such defenses, however, underscore the reality that this wisdom poem does not, in fact, comport with how Job is portrayed in the rest of book, and certainly not in the chapter’s immediate context.

In chapter 27, Job maintains his righteousness (27:1–6) and, as Greenstein notes, parrots many of the nonsensical charges made by his friends.²⁹ Even though the friends have seen the reality of Job’s suffering for themselves, they have simply failed to admit it (27:7–12). Rather than the righteous prospering, they suffer along with the wicked (27:13–23). In chapter 29, Job recalls the glory days (29:2–4) when Shadday was still with him and Job was surrounded by children (29:5–6),³⁰ when he was revered at the city gate (29:7–12), when he defended the weak (29:13–20), and when he had an attentive audience for his counsel (29:21–25). But in chapters 30–31, all that is gone. He is mocked by the youth (30:1–10), abandoned by God (30:11–23), and left to despair in his affliction (30:1–31). Though Job has maintained his integrity and championed the cause of the oppressed (31:1–34, 38–40), Shadday has remained silent,

27. Hartley, *Book of Job*, 373.

28. O’Connor, *Job*, 63–64.

29. Greenstein, *Job*, 117–20.

30. There is some ambiguity as to whether the נַעֲרִים in 29:5 refers to his children or his servants. In each of the four calamities in Job 1, it is always the נַעֲרִים who perish. In each of the first three disasters, the נַעֲרִים undoubtedly refer to Job’s servants. On the death of the נַעֲרִים in the fourth and final calamity, commentators are unanimous in their opinion that this is a veiled reference to Job’s children. However, nowhere in the Book of Job does נַעֲרִים explicitly refer to Job’s children, including Job 29:5, which may refer to his servants or his children. The ics possessive pronoun precludes the likelihood that they are random children from the community.

unwilling even to issue an indictment against Job (31:35–37).³¹ This is not the portrait of a man in search of wisdom or piously resting in the fear of אֱלֹהִים. It is the picture of a man who has tried doing things the right way but has nothing to show for it.

Between these two sets of chapters (27; 29–31) we find the so-called Wisdom Poem, which echoes tropes from the wisdom tradition. It echoes Zophar's platitude that divine knowledge is higher than heaven and deeper than Sheol (11:7–8; 28:12, 20). It reflects the conventional understanding that wisdom is too expensive to purchase (28:18; Prov 8:11). Most notably, it anticipates Elihu's assertion that wisdom is available only to those with whom the spirit of God rests (28:23–28; 32:7–8) and repeats the adage that wisdom is only attainable through the fear of the Lord (28:28; Ps 111:10; Prov 1:7; 9:10; Sir 1:14).

Throughout the Book of Job, only Eliphaz (4:6; 15:4) and Elihu (37:24) have attached wisdom to the fear of God. Declarations of the interlocutors actually to possess wisdom are generally muted. Eliphaz implores Job to listen to him, but he is careful to note that he is merely passing along the wisdom of the ancestors (15:18). Without explicitly acknowledging the obvious, Yahweh implies that He is the one who wove wisdom into the fabric of creation (38:36). It is only Elihu who claims to have attained that wisdom. Job's main concern with wisdom is that even though his friends claim to be speaking with wisdom, their words betray them. Job mocks the friends for pretending to possess wisdom (Job 12:2), leading him to question whether wisdom indeed increases with age (Job 12:12).

Up to this point in the book, Job has not been seeking wisdom. His sentiments towards wisdom have been somewhat jaded. The friends have used proverbial wisdom against him (13:12), and, if there is wisdom to be had, it lies with the deity whom Job sees as a silent adversary. Job has demanded a hearing before the deity to plead his case, but his God has remained uncooperative. Job is not looking for wisdom; he is looking for answers. Neither are the friends looking for wisdom; they suggest they already possess it, even if they do not make the claim outright.

JOB AS THE SPEAKER IN JOB 26–31

The poetic dialogue of chapters 3–37 follows a formulaic pattern whereby each new speaker is introduced by the phrase וַיֹּאמֶר . . . וַיַּעַן.³² The pattern is broken

31. Job's request for a hearing is not merely a request to gain a sympathetic ear but is a continuation from previous chapters of Job's "legal dispute" (Clines, *Job 21–37*, 1033) with the divine.

32. Job 3:1 (Job); 4:1 (Eliphaz); 6:1 (Job); 8:1 (Bildad); 9:1 (Job); 11:1 (Zophar); 12:1 (Job); 15:1 (Eliphaz); 16:1 (Job); 18:1 (Bildad); 19:1 (Job); 20:1 (Zophar); 21:1 (Job); 22:1 (Eliphaz); 23:1 (Job); 25:1 (Bildad); 26:1 (Job); 36:6 (Elihu). Structurally, Job 3 appears to function as a bridge between the prologue

in only two places. One such break occurs in the Elihu speeches where the introductory formula is repeated at both 34:1 and 35:1. It is widely understood that these instances represent the start of separate speeches.³³ In 36:1, however, Elihu's speech is introduced by a variation on the formula: *וַיִּסַּף אֱלִיהוּא וַיֹּאמֶר*. Gordis is undoubtedly correct that this variation "merely registers that Elihu's long address is not yet complete."³⁴

The other break in the pattern occurs in the final six chapters of Job's speeches. Job begins his final speech in 26:1 with the familiar discourse formula *וַיֵּעַן . . . וַיֹּאמֶר*. In both Job 27:1 and 29:1, there is an interruption of Job's speech with the phrase *וַיִּסַּף אֵיּוֹב שֵׁאת מִשְׁלוֹ וַיֹּאמֶר*. Some see the presence of the phrase *שֵׁאת מִשְׁלוֹ* (lit. "took up his proverb") as evidence of the redactive history of the third cycle of speeches.³⁵ However, the phrase itself is also quite formulaic and found exclusively in prophetic discourse,³⁶ suggesting that the words of chapters 27 and 29 are not necessarily an intrusion of a new speaker, but a shift in audience or rhetoric. According to Habel, what immediately follows the expression in both Job 27:1 and Job 29:1 is "a formal declaration,"³⁷ whether as a public oath (27:1) or as public testimony (29:1). These lengthy discourses, then, were likely performative speech, possibly directed at a broader audience beyond Job's three companions.³⁸

In addition to the pattern of the discourse formula, the Book of Job is structured according to the well-known pattern of the discourse cycles, in which each friend speaks in turn, followed by a response from Job. However, this pattern is broken in the third speech cycle by the absence of Zophar, which

and the dialogue, rather than introducing the dialogue portion of the book. Job is responding to the events of chapters 1 and 2, and the friends have yet to provide any comments to which Job can respond. Nonetheless, I have included it with the poetic dialogue unit since it begins the poetic section of the book and begins with the discourse formula *וַיֵּעַן . . . וַיֹּאמֶר*.

33. See, for example, Gordis, *Book of Job*, 509, 530; and Gray, *Book of Job*, 412, 423. Franz Delitzsch suggests the resumption of Elihu's discourse is a result of Job having nothing to say in retort. Franz Delitzsch, "The Book of Job," in C.F. Keil and F. Delitzsch, *Commentary on the Old Testament*, trans. Francis Bolton (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1996; repr. from Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1866–91), 4:241–736, esp. 624.
34. Gordis, *Book of Job*, 412. Although some prefer to delete 36:1 as an editorial addition due to its deviation from 32:6, 34:1 and 35:1, Clines notes this would also require the deletion of 34:2–4. See Clines, *Job 21–37*, 854.
35. Clines, *Job 21–37*, 980; Gordis, *Book of Job*, 287, 318; Pope, *Job*, 189.
36. See, e.g., Num 23:7, 28; 24:3, 15, 20, 21, 23; Isa 14:4; Micah 2:4; Hab 2:6.
37. Norman C. Habel, *The Book of Job*. The Old Testament Library (Philadelphia, PA: Westminster, 1985), 408.
38. In her groundbreaking work, Jacqueline Vayntrub, *Beyond Orality: Biblical Poetry on Its Own Terms* (London: Routledge, 2019), demonstrates that a *משל* is performative speech, "often by named characters" (217). She sees the lifting of a *משל* by Balaam in Num 23–24 and by Isaiah in Isa 14 as "performance" (134, 147), either by the prophet (Balaam) or the audience (Isaiah).

has garnered copious attention among the commentators. Essentially five suggestions have emerged as potential candidates for Zophar's missing third speech: (1) 27:13–23;³⁹ (2) 27:13–23 + 24:18–24;⁴⁰ (3) 27:8–23 + 24:18–20, 22–25;⁴¹ (4) 27:7–12 + 24:18–24 + 27:13–23;⁴² (5) 27:7–10, 13–17 + 24:18–24 + 27:18–23.⁴³ Others see compositional challenges in chapter 27 but interpret them differently. Henning Reventlow sees 27:7–10, 13–23 not as misplaced words of Zophar, but as later insertions from a wisdom psalm.⁴⁴ James Wharton considers 27:13–23 “helplessly scrambled,” such that the dialogues “end in utter confusion rather than resolution.”⁴⁵ Rather than seeing this confusion as a result of careless editing, Katherine Dell wonders whether it might have actually been an intentional rhetorical technique to capture the confusion about who is speaking as the dialogue breaks down.⁴⁶ Still others view the final stanza of chapter 27 as the words of Job sarcastically parroting the words of his friends.⁴⁷ Notably, none of these suggestions attempt to assign chapter 28 to Zophar.

Recently, however, Michael Fox returned to a proposal from nineteenth-century German scholarship that has received little attention, which suggests that Zophar's third speech begins at 27:13 and includes the entirety of chapter 28.⁴⁸ Fox is certainly correct that the language of Job 28 mirrors the language of Zophar's first speech, especially 11:5–9: wisdom is hidden (11:6; 28:12, 20–21); the mysteries of God are higher than heaven and deeper than Sheol (11:8; 28:22); they are longer than heaven and broader than the sea (11:9; 28:23–26). Fox, however, is more interested in shared thematic elements than in similar vocabulary. In Zophar's first speech, God is the sole possessor of wisdom; wisdom is mysterious; God's mind is as incomprehensible as wisdom; although wisdom is hidden, Zophar seems to have some limited understanding of it;

39. Crenshaw, *Reading Job*, 121; Gordis, *Book of Job*, 294–96; Habel, *Book of Job*, 383–87; Lo, *Job* 28, 172–74. Crenshaw and Lo are dissatisfied with the attribution of these verses to Job, but they are noncommittal as to whether they should belong to Zophar or to Bildad.

40. Dhorme, *Book of Job*, 386–98.

41. Pope, *Job*, 187–89.

42. Rowley, *Book of Job*. New Century Bible Commentary (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1976), 175.

43. Clines, *Job* 21–37, 651–63.

44. Henning Graf Reventlow, “Tradition und Redaktion in Hiob 27 im Rahmen der Hiobreden des Abschnittes Hi 24–27,” *Zeitschrift für die alttestamentliche Wissenschaft* 94 (1982): 279–93.

45. Wharton, *Job*, 111.

46. Katherine J. Dell, *Job: An Introduction and Study Guide: Where Shall Wisdom Be Found?* T&T Clark Study Guides to the Old Testament (London: Bloomsbury T&T Clark, 2017), 47.

47. Balentine, *Job*, 399; Newsom, *Book of Job*, 167–68; Hartley, *Book of Job*, 371; Janzen, *Job*, 172–73.

48. Michael V. Fox, “The Speaker in Job 28,” in *When the Morning Stars Sang: Essays in Honor of Choon Leong Seow on the Occasion of His Sixty-Fifth Birthday*, ed. Scott C. Jones and Christine Roy Yoder (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2018), 21–38; Heinrich Graetz, “Die Integrität der Kapitel 27 und 28 im Hiob,” *Monatsschrift für Geschichte und Wissenschaft des Judentums* 21 (1872): 241–50; Johann G.E. Hoffmann, *Hiob* (Kiel: Haeseler, 1891), 28.

God's wisdom ensures justice to be fairly meted out according to one's deeds.⁴⁹ According to Fox, in chapter 28 Zophar "tells Job to stop trying to probe God's wisdom but simply to live in piety and faith," which he had already told him in chapter 11.⁵⁰ This proposal has not gained much traction in the last century and a half in part because the pathos of chapter 28 does not fit with Zophar's other two speeches.⁵¹ Zophar is perhaps the most brazen of the companions, calling Job's words "babble" (בִּבְבֵּל; 11:3) and either directly or indirectly associating Job with the worthless (11:11), the stupid (11:12), and the wicked (11:20; 20:5–29).⁵² Although Zophar's first speech offers Job a path to restoration through repentance (11:13–20), in his second speech he is seemingly resigned to Job's permanent lot (נַחֲלָה; 20:29) among the wicked. Moreover, if Fox is correct that chapter 28 provides "the best approach to inexplicable human suffering – the acceptance of human ignorance before God's wisdom" (and that Zophar is the speaker in chapter 28) – it is hard to reconcile this conclusion with the epilogue in which Zophar, as well as Eliphaz and Bildad, are objects of God's wrath for having not spoken rightly about God, and require atoning sacrifices and Job's prayers (42:7–9).

INTERPRETING כִּי

If we understand Job 27 and Job 29–31 as a continuation of Job's discourse perhaps aimed at a broader audience, the question now is raised as to what to make of Job 28. In addition to the aforementioned stylistic changes in Job 28, there is an additional disruption in the discourse pattern that has given interpreters pause with respect to the chapter's function in the book. Whereas chapters 27 and 29 each begin *וַיֹּאמֶר מִשְׁלוֹ שְׂאֵת כִּי*, chapter 28 begins with the particle *כִּי*. Although *כִּי* has a wide semantic range, it almost invariably introduces a dependent clause. That is, what follows *כִּי* logically flows from what precedes it.⁵³ However, in light of the previous discussion, it is clear to most scholars that what follows the *כִּי* in Job 28 does not, in fact, logically follow what precedes it in Job 27.⁵⁴

49. Fox, "The Speaker in Job 28," 33.

50. Fox, "The Speaker in Job 28," 38.

51. Gordis, *Book of God and Man*, 102, notes chapter 28 "is entirely inappropriate for the impetuous, hot-headed Zophar."

52. Seow, *Job 1–21: Interpretation and Commentary*. Illuminations (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2013), 835.

53. See, e.g., Bill T. Arnold and John H. Choi, *A Guide to Biblical Hebrew Syntax*, 2nd ed. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2018), 160–66.

54. Clines (*Job 21–37*, 894) notes that "even if we accept that chap. 28 was originally preceded by chap. 27 ... there is nothing there for which the material of chap. 28 could be the reason." Likewise,

Despite Greenstein's contention that "[b]iblical poems do not begin with the conjunction *ki*,"⁵⁵ several scholars have pointed to Isaiah 15:1 as evidence to the contrary.⁵⁶

Because (כי)⁵⁷ Ar was desolated in a night,
Moab is silenced.

Because (כי) Kir was desolated in a night,
Moab is silenced.⁵⁸

However, it should be noted that כי in Isaiah 15:1 does not introduce an entire poem; it is used twice to introduce two separate independent clauses in which the usual syntax is reversed to emphasize the cause of the impending judgment.⁵⁹ If Isaiah 15:1 is the only supporting evidence for a unit of biblical poetry initiated by כי, then Greenstein's position withstands scrutiny. The most common way of handling כי in Job 28:1, then, is to treat it as an asseverative particle of declaration⁶⁰ or to leave it untranslated altogether.⁶¹

Tur-Sinai offers an alternative explanation for the function of כי in Job 28. In his estimation, the כי introduces "a quotation from a certain type of ancient

Driver and Gray assert that "in the present context of the chapter nothing has preceded, the reason for which can be contained in the verses which now follow" (*A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Book of Job together with a New Translation*, Vol. II. International Critical Commentary [New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1921], 190). H.H. Rowley comments that its presence implies "that it once had a preceding context" (*The Book of Job*, 179.)

55. Greenstein, *Job*, 160.

56. Clines, *Job* 21–37, 894; Gordis, *Book of Job*, 304; Hartley, *Book of Job*, 373.

57. John D.W. Watts (*Isaiah* 1–33. Word Biblical Commentary 24 [Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 1985], 223) renders the כי in Isa 15:1 as "Indeed!"

58. Unless otherwise noted, all translations are my own.

59. Anneli Aejmelaesus ("Function and Interpretation of כי in BH," *Journal of Biblical Literature* 105/2 [1986]:193–209) refers to this type of construction as a "circumstantial כי clause" (196). A similar construction is also found in Gen 3:14–15: "Because (כי) you have done this, cursed are you among all animals and among all wild creatures."

60. Clines, *Job* 21–37, 894; Gordis, *Book of Job*, 304; Gray, *Book of Job*, 343; Habel, *Book of Job*, 389; Hartley, *Book of Job*, 373; Gustav Hölscher, *Das Buch Hiob*. Handbuch zum Alten Testament (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 1937), 66; Longman, *Job*, 324; Jones, *Rumors of Wisdom*, 123; ESV; HCSB; NASB; NAB; NET; NRSVue. Although Édouard Dhorme (*Book of Job* [Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 1984], 399) does not find any semantic significance in the particle, he nonetheless renders it as "surely," which has an equivalent effect as the asseverative function. In his review of Josef Tropper's *Ugaritisch Grammatik*, Dennis Pardee refutes the widespread use of asseverative כי in Ugaritic prose and notes that the few remaining examples in poetic texts are dubious. Dennis Pardee, review of *Ugaritisch Grammatik*, by J. Tropper, *Archiv für Orientforschung* 50 (2003–04): 383–84. GKC §149 notes that כי rarely functions as an asseverative particle, citing only Gen 22:16 as an example.

61. CEB; CEV; NEB; NIV; NJPS; NLT.

literature or, more exactly, from a variety thereof in Israelite-Jewish garb.”⁶² For Tur-Sinai, this also explains the presence of the lone instance of אֲדֹנִי in the Book of Job. Similarly, Michael Austin likens Job 28 to Proverbs 8 and 9, hymns to wisdom that existed in Israelite culture prior to the books in which they ultimately landed. With respect to Job 28, “it was interpolated into the Book of Job by somebody who either saw or wanted to create a connection between it and the rest of the text.”⁶³

In fact, it is well attested that כִּי occasionally functions to introduce direct speech, such as a quotation, oath formula, or interrogative.⁶⁴ A few examples will suffice to demonstrate.⁶⁵

Quotation

Ruth 1:10

ותאמרנה־לָהּ כִּי־אתָךְ נשוב לעמך:

They said to her, [כִּי] “We will return with you to your people.”

Ezekiel 33:10

ואתה בן־אדם אמר אל־בית ישראל כן אמרתם לאמר כִּי־פשעֵינוּ וחטאתֵינוּ עלינו וּבָם
אנחנו נמקים ואֵיךְ נחיה:

Now, O human, say to the house of Israel: “Thus you have said, [כִּי] ‘Our transgressions and our sins are upon us and we are rotting with them. How can we live?’”

62. Tur-Sinai, *Book of Job*, 395.

63. Michael Austin, *Re-reading Job: Understanding the Ancient World’s Greatest Poem* (Draper, UT: Greg Kofford, 2014), 61. Austin does not provide any evidence that Proverbs 8 and 9 existed elsewhere prior to their incorporation into the Book of Proverbs, nor does he explain how other poems in Psalms or Proverbs only existed in their canonical format.

64. Aejmelaeus, “Function and Interpretation,” 208; Arnold and Choi, *Biblical Hebrew Syntax*, 165; GKC, 491; W.T. Claussen, “Speaker-Oriented Functions of כִּי in Biblical Hebrew,” *JNSL* 11 (1983): 29–46; C.L. Seow, *A Grammar for Biblical Hebrew*, rev. ed. (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 1995), Ronald J. Williams, *Hebrew Syntax: An Outline*, 2nd ed. (Toronto: University of Toronto, 1976; repr. 1996), 73.

65. It is important to note that in each of these cases כִּי could be translated as “that,” indicating indirect speech, rather than direct speech. With the exception of 1 Sam 14:44 (see the accompanying footnote), modern versions are unanimous in their treatment of כִּי in these passages as introducing direct speech.

Oath

1 Samuel 14:44

וַיֹּאמֶר שָׂאוּל כֹּה־יַעֲשֶׂה אֱלֹהִים וְכֹה יוֹסֵף כִּי־מוֹת תָּמוּת יוֹנָתָן:

Then Saul said, “Thus God will do and thus He will proceed; [כי] ‘you shall surely die.’”⁶⁶

1 Kings 1:17

וַתֹּאמֶר לוֹ אֲדָנִי אַתָּה נִשְׁבַּעַת בַּיהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ לְאַמְתֶּךָ כִּי־שְׁלֹמֹה בְנֶךָ יִמְלֹךְ אַחֲרַי וְהוּא יֵשֵׁב עַל־כִּסְאִי:

She said to him, “My lord, you swore by Yahweh your God to your maid-servant, [כי] ‘Solomon your son will reign after me and it is he who will sit on my throne.’”

Interrogative

Genesis 27:36

וַיֹּאמֶר הֲכִי קָרָא שְׁמוֹ יַעֲקֹב

Then he asked, [כי] “Is his name not called Jacob?”⁶⁷

2 Sam 9:1

וַיֹּאמֶר דָּוִד הֲכִי יֵשְׁעוֹד אֲשֶׁר נֹתַר לְבֵית שָׂאוּל וְאֶעֱשֶׂה עִמּוֹ חֶסֶד בַּעֲבוּר יְהוֹנָתָן:

Then David asked, [כי] “Is there still anyone remaining from the house of Saul that I might show loyalty for the sake of Jonathan?”

66. Modern versions typically render כי as “if not”; see also Ralph W. Klein, *1 Samuel*, 2nd ed. Word Biblical Commentary 10 (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2000), 131. In his treatment of כי in relation to oath formulas, Blane Conklin (*Oath Formulas in Biblical Hebrew* כי. Linguistic Studies in Ancient West Semitic 5 [Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2011], 48) notes that 1 Sam 14:44 is one of ten instances in which כי is “unassignable.” Nonetheless, he sees the primary function of כי within oath formulas as a “complementizer,” e.g., “I swear that” (59), which would suggest *indirect*, rather than *direct* speech. Contrary to Yael Ziegler, “So Shall God Do...: Variations of an Oath Formula and Its Literary Meaning,” *Journal of Biblical Literature* 126 (2007): 59–81, esp. 60. Conklin rejects the notion of an emphatic function of כי within oaths.

67. According to GKC §150e, one use of כי in interrogative statements, as exemplified in Gen 27:36, “serves to merely express the conviction that the contents of the statement are well known to the hearer and are unconditionally admitted by him.” Paul Joüon, (*A Grammar of Biblical Hebrew*, trans. Takamitsu Muraoka. Subsidia Biblica 27, 2nd ed. [Rome: Editrice Pontificio Instituto Biblico, 2006], §161j) likens הכי to French *est-ce que?*, “is it the case that?”

Proverb

Another form of direct speech that כִּי occasionally introduces is the proverb. In these cases, the particle retains a vestige of its causal function. When cited in a narrative context, proverbs provide communal support for a desired action. They represent the collective wisdom of the community, past and present. The particle כִּי is appropriately used to introduce the proverb as the proverb supplies the rationale for the advice. The Book of Proverbs is replete with such examples, where the proverb often follows a command, prohibition, warning, or promise.⁶⁸ In these cases, the proverb invokes the collective wisdom of the community as rationale for proper behavior. This pattern can also be found in some instances outside the Book of Proverbs.

Deuteronomy 16:19

לֹא־תַטֶּה מִשְׁפָּט לֹא תִכִּיר פָּנִים וְלֹא־תִקַּח שֹׁחַד כִּי הַשֹּׁחַד יַעֲוֶר עֵינֵי חֲכָמִים וְיִסְלֹף דְּבָרֵי צְדִיקִים:

You shall neither pervert justice nor show partiality. You shall not take a bribe, for [כִּי] “A bribe blinds the eyes of the wise and subverts the words of the righteous.”⁶⁹

The Book of Proverbs contains four such admonitions about the folly of accepting bribes,⁷⁰ including Proverbs 17:23, which is conceptually equivalent to the proverb in Deuteronomy 16:19.

שֹׁחַד מַחִיק רֶשַׁע יִקַּח לַהֲטוֹת אֲרָחוֹת מִשְׁפָּט:

The wicked take a bribe in secret
to pervert the paths of justice.

Whereas Deuteronomy 16:19 addresses the effects a bribe has on the wise and the righteous, Proverbs 17:23 observes how the wicked use bribery to distort justice. In Deuteronomy 16:19 the proverb provides the rationale for the commandment, “You shall not take a bribe.” If the community will not heed the words of Moses or Yahweh, perhaps they will heed the collective wisdom of its sages.

68. Prov 1:8–9, 15–17, 29–32; 2:4–6, 9–10, 16–18, 2:20–21; 3:11–12, 25–26; 4:13, 15–17; 5:1–3, 20–21; 6:3, 22–23, 25–26; 7:1–6, 25–26; 8:10–11, 34–35; 9:10–11, 18; 11:15; 16:12, 26; 20:16; 21:25; 22:9, 23:5, 6–7, 9–11, 20–21, 26–27; 24:1–2, 5–6, 15–16, 19–20, 21–22; 25:6–7, 21–22, 26:25; 27:1 (and possibly 27:13), 23–24; 29:19; 30:32–33.

69. On Deut 16:19b as a proverb, see, for example, Adolph L. Harstad, *Deuteronomy: A Theological Exposition of Sacred Scripture*. Concordia Commentary (St. Louis, MO: Concordia, 2022), 472; Richard D. Nelson, *Deuteronomy: A Commentary*. The Old Testament Library (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2002), 219.

70. Prov 6:35; 17:8, 23; 21:14.

1 Samuel 16:7

ויאמר יהוה אל־שמואל אל־תבט אל־מראהו ואל־גבה קומתו כי מאסתיהו כי לא אשר
יראה האדם כי האדם יראה לעינים ויהוה יראה ללבב:

But Yahweh said to Samuel, “Do not look at his appearance or at his height or stature, because [כי] I have rejected him,” for [כי] ‘it is not what the human sees.’⁷¹ For [כי] ‘the human sees according to the eyes, but Yahweh sees according to the heart.’⁷²

The shift from Yahweh’s direct command to Samuel to a generic platitude about how the human sees is suggestive that כי introduces an aphorism to bolster the imperative. Not only does the subject switch from first person to third person, but the statement itself is pithy and generic, a common feature of proverbs, allowing them to be deployed in a variety of contexts. Moreover, the subject of the verb יראה is ambiguous and could refer to an impersonal “one,” a generic “he,” or Yahweh. Since this is direct speech from Yahweh, the last option seems least likely. Rather than contrasting how “I” (Yahweh) see with how “you” (Samuel) see, the two כי clauses contrast how an impersonal “one/he” sees with how a generic האדם sees. What is less clear, however, is whether 1 Samuel 16:7 contains one or two proverbs. Both כי clauses contain the words יראה and האדם, suggesting they are part of the same proverb. However, the first clause reads יראה האדם and the second clause reads האדם יראה, followed by a contrast between how האדם sees and how Yahweh sees, a syntactical feature commonly found in poetic proverbs. Although it is uncommon in the Book of Proverbs to find two consecutive aphorisms supporting one imperative, there is at least one example.

Leave it alone! Do not travel on it!
Turn away from it and keep moving!
For (כי) they do not sleep unless they do evil;
they are deprived of sleep unless they wreak havoc.
For (כי) they eat the bread of wickedness;
and drink the wine of violence. (Prov 4:15–17)

71. NRSVue is representative of the consensus opinion on this clause: “for the Lord does not see as mortals see.” However, this translation infers Yahweh as the subject of the verb יראה, which has an additional subject in האדם. By contrast, note the NJPS, “for not as man sees” and its predecessor, the JPS 1917, “for it is not as man seeth.”

72. In the case of 1 Sam 16:7, what follows the final כי was not yet recognized as a maxim in the Israelite community at this juncture but would become one from this point forward. See, for example, Joyce G. Baldwin, 1 & 2 Samuel: *An Introduction & Commentary*. Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries 8 (Downers Grove, IL: Inter-Varsity, 1988), 122; and Tony W. Cartledge, 1 & 2 Samuel. Smyth & Helwys Bible Commentary (Macon, GA: Smyth & Helwys, 2001), 201.

Given the analogy with Proverbs 4:15–17, and with similar examples in the Book of Job,⁷³ I am inclined to favor the notion that 1 Samuel 16:7 consists of two complementary proverbs to bolster the single command of Yahweh.

Ecclesiastes 5:1 [Eng. 5:2]

אל-תבהל על-פיך ולבך אל-ימהר להוציא דבר לפני האלהים כי האלהים בשמים ואתה על-הארץ על-כן יהיו דבריך מעטים:

Do not be hasty with your mouth or your heart. Do not be quick to bring forth a word before God, for [כי] “God is in heaven, but you are on earth.” Therefore, let your words be few.

Nili Samet has demonstrated the prevalence of this proverb, or variations thereof, throughout the ancient Near East, including in numerous biblical passages.⁷⁴ This adage serves as a reminder that humans are lesser beings than האלהים, and should thus be careful about speaking to the divine.

The proverbial use of כי is also featured in the Book of Job, occurring at least a dozen times.⁷⁵ I will look at one example each from Eliphaz, Bildad, and Elihu.⁷⁶

73. See, e.g., Job 5:5–7; 8:9. On Job 8:9, see Norman C. Habel “Appeal to Ancient Tradition.” *Zeitschrift für die alttestamentliche Wissenschaft* 88 (1976): 253–63.

74. Nili Samet, “The Tallest Man Cannot Reach Heaven; The Broadest Man Cannot Cover Earth” – Reconsidering the Proverb and Its Biblical Parallels,” *The Journal of Hebrew Scriptures* 10, art. 18 (2010):1–13. Among the ANE examples, Samet cites Gilgamesh and Huwawa, Sumerian Proverbs, The Ballade of Early Rulers, Dialogue of Pessimism, *Ludlul bēl nēmeqi*, Babylonian Theodicy, and EA 264. In the biblical corpus, Samet identifies Deut 30:11–14; Isa 14:13–14; Jer 31:36; Amos 9:2–3; Job 11:7–9; 28:12–28; Ps 115:15–16; 139:8–10; Prov 30:4. Modern English translations treat האלהים as the Israelite God, which is supported by the prevalence (32×) of האלהים throughout Qohelet, while anarthous אלהים is attested only 8 times. However, as a proverb that circulated throughout the ancient Near East in various forms, the universal nature of the proverb leaves open the possibility that האלהים might best be rendered more generically as “the gods” in this context, but given Qohelet’s preference for האלהים, this cannot be argued with much certainty. Gordis points to Eccl 5:1 as preserving only a portion of a known proverb, noting also that proverbs are often quoted devoid of their original context. The hearers need only recognize a portion of the proverb to make the broader connection to the full source. See especially Robert L. Gordis, “Quotations as a Literary Usage in Biblical, Oriental, and Rabbinic Literature,” *Hebrew Union College Annual* 22 (1949):157–219, esp. 200.

75. Proverbial sayings play an important rhetorical strategy in Job. As Job declares in Job 13:12, the friends’ use of proverbs is weaponized against Job, offering meaningless consolation to Job’s suffering. The book employs several particles to introduce proverbs, including גם (18:5), הן (8:19), and הנה (5:17). The most predominantly used particle, however, is כי (5:2, 5, 6, 7, 18; 8:8, 9; 15:34; 22:2b; 34:3, 11, 21). See also Edward L. Greenstein, “Proverbs and Popular Sayings, Real or Invented, in the Book of Job,” in *Teaching Morality in Antiquity: Wisdom Texts, Oral Traditions, and Images*, ed. T.M. Oshima with Susanne Kohlhaas (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2018), 137–49.

76. I have only been able to identify one proverb from Zophar, occurring in Job 11:12, but it is not

Job 5:1–2 (Eliphaz)

קרא־נא היש עונך ואל־מי מקדשים תפנה:
כי־לאויל יהרג־כעש ופתה תמית קנאה:

Call now! Is there anyone who answers you?
To whom among the holy ones will you turn?
For (כי) “Vexation murders a fool,
and jealousy kills the simple.”

In Job 5:1, Eliphaz uses a set of rhetorical questions to challenge Job to look only to God for recourse, rather than to other humans or a member of the divine council.⁷⁷ Clines notes that the intrusion of the “fool” in Job 5:2, which only appears elsewhere in the book at 2:10 and 30:8, betrays this verse as a proverb, as does its symmetrical construction of two stichs comprised of three synonymous word-pairs.⁷⁸ As with several of the previous examples, the proverb is preceded by a command and invokes the collective wisdom of the community as rationale for proper behavior.

Job 8:8–9 (Bildad)

כי־שאל־נא לדר רישון וכוונן לחקר אבותם:
כי־תמול אנחנו ולא נדע כי צל ימינו עלי־ארץ:

For (כי),⁷⁹ inquire of former generations,
give attention to the findings of their fathers.
For (כי) “We are as yesterday, not knowing;”
(כי) “Our days are a shadow on the earth.”

Norman Habel identifies the genre of Job 8:8–20 as an appeal to ancient tradition, which consists of “an opening formula of appeal such as ‘Ask now’ (*šē’al-nā*);

introduced by a particle. It is also possible that Job 11:11 is a proverb, and it is introduced by **כי**, but its status as a proverb is not overtly obvious.

77. C.L. Seow, *Job 1–21*, 415. For a survey of interpretations of Job 5:1, see David J.A. Clines, “Job 5, 1–8: A New Exegesis,” *Biblica* 62 (1981): 185–94.
78. David J.A. Clines, *Job 1–20*. Word Biblical Commentary 17 (Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 1989), 138. See also Ballentine, *Job*, 112; Hartley, *Book of Job*, 117; Longman, *Job*, 122–23; Pope, *Job*, 42; Seow, *Job 1–21*, 415; Tur-Sinai, *Book of Job*, 93–94; Wharton, *Job*, 32. On the verse’s proverbial nature due to parallelism, see Gordis, *Book of Job*, 52.
79. Seow (*Job 1–21*, 530), understands **כי** in Job 8:8 to be emphatic, and “brings the confirmation of previous statements” (Dhorme, *Book of Job*, 116). Gordis (*Book of Job*, 86) and Tur-Sinai (*Book of Job*, 148) see it as a logical connector between 8:2–7 and 8:8ff. Others leave **כי** untranslated (e.g., Clines, *Job 1–27*, 197; Gray, *Book of Job*, 84; Greenstein, *Job*, 35; Habel, *Book of Job*, 168; Hartley, *Book of Job*, 158; Pope, *Job*, 64). Whichever the case, the imperatives following the **כי** in Job 8:8 do not appear to be proverbial in nature.

the designation of the past as primal or ancient; the citation of a known tradition, often in proverbial form; and the application of the teaching of that tradition to a particular situation.”⁸⁰ According to Habel, verses 9–10 constitute “the rationale for the appeal” and verse 11 is the recitation of an Egyptian proverb.⁸¹ There is consensus among interpreters that Bildad’s appeal to the collective wisdom of the past traditions (אבות) is effective due to the assumption that “all knowledge was mediated by a chain of tradition.”⁸² In Mesopotamia and Egypt in particular, this tradition “served to reinforce the sense of loyalty to the established order, while at the same time encouraging blind faith in the gods, especially in times of trial and adversity.”⁸³ The premise to Bildad’s rhetorical strategy comes with his expectation that the tradition is without dispute.

While verse 8 provides the injunction for seeking the wisdom of the ancestors, verse 9 provides the rationale. Life is fleeting; no matter the duration of one’s life, it will not match the collective years represented in the tradition. Verse 9 contains two separate clauses, both introduced by the particle כִּי. Both clauses are formulaic, and both contain expressions of ephemerality found elsewhere in the biblical wisdom corpus.⁸⁴ Moreover, as commonly found in proverbial diction, each clause is pithy and easily memorized with hints of alliteration. As with the previous example in Job 5:2, the proverbs here in Job 8:9 follow a direct command, and provide the rationale for obedience. Ironically, Bildad appeals to the collective wisdom of the tradition to persuade Job to seek the collective wisdom of the tradition.

Job 34:2–3 (Elihu)

שמעו חכמים מלי וידעים האזינו לי:
כִּי־אֶזֶן מִלִּין תִּבְחַן וְחָךְ יִטַּעַם לֹא־כֹל:

80. Habel, *Book of Job*, 171; Habel, “Appeal to Ancient Tradition,” 253–71.

81. Habel (*Book of Job*, 176) notes that the terms for “papyrus” (גמא) and “reed” (אחו) are most likely Egyptian loanwords, which Greenstein states with more certainty (*Job*, 36). The appeal to an Egyptian proverb would have a profound rhetorical effect since Egypt was “a distant land renowned for its wisdom and symbols of enduring antiquity” (Habel, *Book of Job*, 176–77).

82. James L. Crenshaw, *Old Testament Wisdom: An Introduction*, 3rd ed. (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2010), 6. Elihu appeals to this sentiment in Job 32:7. I think Greenstein is correct to identify Job 8:8–12 as a “flourish” of “proverbial expressions,” though only verses 8–9 are introduced by כִּי. The maxims in verses 10–11 are presented as interrogatives, while the adage in verse 12 is stated without introduction. Greenstein, “Proverbs and Popular Sayings,” 142.

83. Paul-Alain Beaulieu, “The Social and Intellectual Setting of Babylonian Wisdom Literature,” in *Wisdom Literature in Mesopotamia and Israel*, ed. Richard J. Clifford. SBL Symposium Series 66 (Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2007), 3–19, esp. p. 3. See also Wilfred G. Lambert, *Babylonian Wisdom Literature* (Oxford: Oxford University, 1960; repr. Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 1996), 1–20.

84. Job 14:2; Ps 90:9–10; 102:3 (4 HB), 11 (12 HB); 144:4; Eccl 6:12; 8:13.

Hear my words, O wise men.
 Give ear to me, O knowing ones;
 for (כִּי) “the ear tests words,
 and the palate tastes food.”

After twice imploring Job to listen to his words (see Job 33:1, 31), Elihu now pleads with his friends to give him a hearing. In so doing he recites Job's own words almost verbatim from Job 12:11.⁸⁵ Whereas Job inquired whether the ear tests words or the palate tastes food, for Elihu it is a matter of certainty that serves as the rationale for his friends to pay attention to him. Although it is evident here that the particle כִּי is at least introducing direct speech from Job,⁸⁶ there is broad agreement that both Job 34:3 and Job 12:11 represent a well-known adage.⁸⁷

JOB 28 AS EXTERNAL POEM

Returning now to Job 28, it is worth considering whether the particle כִּי might also function to introduce third-party speech in this particular case, especially given the canonical arrangement in which Job is the speaker in the surrounding chapters. As we have already seen, Tur-Sinai suggests כִּי is operating in precisely this manner. Although there is no direct evidence linking Job 28 to an independent wisdom poem, there are at least four features in the poem to alert readers that the poem should be understood as external to the speaker.

The first, and most obvious feature, is that its contents do not align with the sentiments of Job. These stanzas stand in stark contrast to Job's public oath in chapter 27 and his public declaration in chapter 29 concerning justice and the failure of the retribution principle. Given the fact that Job has expressed his desire to escape suffering by descending to the land of no return (18:21–22), it hardly seems logical that he would now care that wisdom is beyond human reach (28:13).⁸⁸ Given the fact that Job has lost everything, including his friends and his status, it is curious that Job would care that wisdom is more costly than pearls (28:17). Given that both the narrator and Yahweh attest to the fact that Job has turned from evil (סֵר מַרַע; 1:1, 8; 2:3), it seems unlikely that Job would believe that turning from evil (סֹר מַרַע; 28:28) which he does not

85. Following Edwin M. Good (*In Turns of Tempest*, 327), Ballentine (*Job*, 568) views the slight disagreements between Job's words here and elsewhere in the Elihu speeches as not inconsequential and suggests a deliberate distortion on the part of Elihu.

86. Elihu quotes or alludes to Job's own words in Job 34:5–6.

87. Balentine, *Job*, 566; Gordis, *Book of Job*, 386; Dhorme, *Book of Job*, 509; Greenstein, *Job*, 143; Konkel, *Job*, 201; Wharton, *Job*, 147.

88. This point is especially valid if Jones is correct that the location described in Job 28 refers to the land beyond the cosmic sea (Jones, *Rumors of Wisdom*; also, see above, note 17).

believe he has committed (16:17; 27:6) would somehow lead to understanding, especially since the deity has not been forthcoming with Job despite Job's persistent pleas. Whatever the source of Job 28 may be, it does not reflect the sentiments of Job.

The second feature pertains to the source of wisdom. Two sets of rhetorical questions related to the source of wisdom and understanding are repeated almost verbatim in two verses.

Where shall wisdom be found? Where is the place of understanding?

(28:12)

Where does wisdom come from?⁸⁹ Where is the place of understanding?

(28:20)

Although these exact phrases appear nowhere else in the Hebrew Bible, the pairing of wisdom (חכמה) and understanding (בינה) is only found fourteen times outside of Job 28, seven times in the Book of Proverbs, and two in the Book of Job, both of which occurring in the divine speeches.⁹⁰ Not only does this repetition of the בינה/חכמה pairing draw on the broader Israelite wisdom tradition, its connection with the deep (28:14) is reminiscent of *Ludlul Bēl Nēmeqi* II, 37:

mi-lik šá an-za-nun-ze-e i-ḥa-ak-kim man-nu

Who understands the counsel of the deep?⁹¹

Readers of Job 28, then, would likely recognize the בינה/חכמה pairing as foreign to the Joban speeches, but reflective of a recognizable wisdom trope.

A third feature is the cost of חכמה and בינה. Contrasting חכמה and בינה with various precious gems and metals, Job 28:14–19 declares חכמה and בינה priceless. They cannot be purchased with even the most expensive currency. This concept is not novel to the Book of Job. Rather, it correlates with conventional wisdom as articulated in the Book of Proverbs. In Proverbs 3:13–15, the value of חכמה and בינה are beyond that of silver, gold, and jewels. In Proverbs 16:16, they exceed the

89. The only difference in wording between Job 28:12 and Job 28:20 is the final verb of the first stich. Job 28:12a reads תמצא (3fs Niph impf), while Job 28:20a reads תבוא (3fs Qal impf).

90. Deut 4:6; Isa 11:2; 29:14; Job 28:12, 20, 28; 38:36; 39:17; Prov 1:2; 4:5, 7; 7:4; 9:10; 16:16; 23:23; Dan 1:20; 2:20.

91. Takayoshi Oshima, *Babylonian Poems of Pious Sufferers: Ludlul Bel Nemeqi and the Babylonian Theodicy*. *Orientalische Religionen in der Antike* 14 (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2014), 88–89. See also Amar Annus and Alan Lenzi, *Ludlul bēl nēmeqi: The Standard Babylonian Poem of the Righteous Sufferer*, *State Archives of Assyria Cuneiform Texts* 7 (Helsinki: Neo-Assyrian Text Corpus Project, 2010), 20, 35; Enrique Jiménez, “The Distant Plans of the Gods (*Ludlul* II, 36–38),” *Kaskal* 16 (2019): 79–81. Oshima (247) notes that the *anzanunzû* in *Ludlul* and elsewhere in Akkadian literature refers to the subterranean waters, synonymous with the Apsû, and conceptually equivalent to תהום in Job 28:14 (see Gen 1:2; Ps 104:6; Prov 8:27).

worth of silver and gold. Job 28 appeals to the identifiable wisdom theme of the costly nature of חכמה and בינה to solidify their incomprehensible essence.

The fourth feature is the inclusion of אדני, its lone occurrence in the Book of Job (28:28). Many commentators have, in fact, pointed to the presence of this feature as evidence of the chapter's intrusive nature.⁹² The phrase יראת אדני not only supplants ירא אלהים from the prologue (1:1, 3; 2:8); it replaces the more formulaic יהוה יראת that frequents the Book of Proverbs.⁹³ While some see יראת אדני as forming an *inclusio* with 1:1, its deviation from the script might better be understood as intentional. Perhaps the reference to אדני was another way of drawing attention to the foreignness of the book. Perhaps, as Fohrer asserts, it was a "prosaische Nachschrift" introducing the divine epithet for the first – and only – time in the book.⁹⁴ Or, perhaps, its inclusion is an intentional literary device to mark the chapter as an external source.

JOB 28 AS SARCASTIC WISDOM POEM

If the particle כי does, in fact, introduce third-party speech, we must now ask what kind of speech? Claus Westermann calls the poem of Job 28 "an expansion on a short proverb which consists of a question (v. 12 = v. 20) and an answer (v. 23); in other words, it is a riddle, consisting of a problem and its solution."⁹⁵ For Westermann, the poem cannot belong to Job or any of the friends. Rather, following the same structure of Proverbs 23:29–30 and Ecclesiastes 8:1, Job 28 is an expansion of a proverb, in this case, "where shall wisdom be found, and where is the place of understanding"? (28:20). However, he observes that the poem's overall pessimism concerning wisdom's accessibility stands in contrast to Proverbs 1–9, which frequently admonishes the student to "acquire wisdom"

92. See, e.g., Clines, *Job 21–37*, 924; Crenshaw, *Reading Job*, 124; Rowley, *Book of Job*, 234; Hartley, *Book of Job*, 383; Pope, *Job*, 206. The unexpected appearance of אדני is not lost on the versions: LXX = ἡ θεοσεβεία ("the fear of God"); Peshitta Job = ܐܠܗܝܡ (God); TgJob = יי (abbrev. of Yahweh). Another concern is that v. 28 stands in contrast to the rest of the chapter. Whereas in Job 28:1–27, wisdom is beyond the reach of human capacity, Job 28:28 suddenly reverses course and declares it to be quite accessible. See, e.g., Clines, *Job 21–37*, 923; and William P. Brown, *Wisdom's Wonder: Character, Creation, and Crisis in the Bible's Wisdom Literature* (Grand Rapids, IL: Eerdmans, 2014), 88. Habel (*Book of Job*, 401), by contrast, sees a complementary tension between "[w]isdom as a mysterious preexistent principle of God acquired and employed by God in the ordering and organization of the universe" as described in Job 28:1–27, and wisdom "as a way of understanding the world which is ultimately only attainable by mortals with 'the fear of Yahweh' as their point of departure" as depicted in Job 28:28.

93. Prov 1:7, 29; 2:5; 8:13; 9:10; 10:27; 14:26; 15:33; 16:6; 19:23; 22:4; 23:17; 31:30.

94. Fohrer, *Studien zum Buche Hiob*, 392.

95. Claus Westermann, *The Structure of the Book of Job: A Form-Critical Analysis*, trans. C.A. Muenchow (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1981), 135.

(e.g., Prov 4:5). Scott Jones follows a similar vein, calling Job 28 a “parabolic subversion of the search for wisdom.”⁹⁶ In fact, Newsom has observed that the sentiments of Job 28 would have been “vigorously” resisted by Job, since “divine perversity rather than *hokmāh*” is a more appropriate way to account for reality.⁹⁷ As I have shown earlier, there is little, if any, dispute on this matter. The essence of Job 28 stands in contrast to the rest of Job’s speeches. How, then, can Job be the speaker of chapter 28 if it runs against the grain of everything else he has to say in the book?

According to Quintillian’s classic definition, irony is speech “in which something contrary to what is said is to be understood (*contrarium ei quod dicitur intelligendum est*).”⁹⁸ Sarcasm, on the other hand, is “a type of irony more offensive with the intent to convey scorn or mock a clear victim.”⁹⁹ A surprising amount of research has been conducted on sarcasm detection, a rhetorical device much more easily identified with vocal clues, but more challenging to detect in written communication when such clues may only be provided by orthography or punctuation.¹⁰⁰ Not only does this line of research have implications for linguistic and communication theory, it also has applications related to artificial intelligence and social media algorithms. One such study focusing on sarcasm detection in oral communication notes that one of the challenges of collecting data is that sarcasm is “indicative of informal speech,” and thus is more likely to occur “among close friends than between strangers.”¹⁰¹ Another study has concentrated on the analysis of tweets in the broader context of the users’ tweet history. Here, it was determined that if a new tweet deviated from previous sentiments from the same user, it was highly predictable that the deviating tweet was sarcastic in nature.¹⁰² Yet another study has explored the use of explicit and implicit incongruity, in which the speaker says things that

96. Jones, *Rumors of Wisdom*, 242.

97. Newsom, *Book of Job*, 176.

98. Gregory Vlastos, “Socratic Irony,” *The Classical Quarterly* 37 (1987): 79–87, esp. 79; citing Quintillian, *Institutio Oratoria* 9.22.44.

99. Simona Frenda, et al., “The Unbearable Hurtfulness of Sarcasm,” *Expert Systems with Applications* 193 (2022), n.p. <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0957417421016870>

100. Elizabeth Rohar, “Unmarked Modality and Rhetorical Questions in Biblical Hebrew,” in *Studies in Semitic Linguistics and Manuscripts: A Liber Discipulorum in Honour of Professor Geoffrey Khan*, ed. Nadia Vidro, Ronny Vollandt, Esther-Miriam Wagner, and Judith Olszowy-Schlanger. *Studia Semitica Upsaliensia* 30 (Uppsala, Sweden: Acta Universitatis Upsaliensis, 2018): 75–97.

101. Rachel Rakov and Andrew Rosenberg, “‘Sure, I Did the Right Thing’: A System for Sarcasm Detection in Speech,” *Proceedings of Interspeech*, Lyon, France, 2013: 842–46, esp. 843; https://www.isca-speech.org/archive_vo/archive_papers/interspeech_2013/i13_o842.pdf

102. Anupam Khattri, Aditya Joshi, Pushpak Bhattacharyya, and Mark James Carman, “Your Sentiment Precedes You: Using an Author’s Historical Tweets to Predict Sarcasm,” *6th Workshop on Computational Approaches to Subjectivity, Sentiment and Social Media Analysis (WASSA)*

are obviously at odds with their intended sentiment. Explicit incongruity “is overtly expressed through sentiment words of both polarities (as in the case of ‘*I love being ignored*’ where there is a positive word ‘*love*’ and a negative word ‘*ignored*’).” Implicit incongruity “is covertly expressed through phrases of implied sentiment, as opposed to opposing polar words,” as in the statement “*I love this paper so much that I made a doggy bag out of it*,” where the clause “I made a doggy bag out of it” is implicitly incongruous with the verb “love.”¹⁰³

There are several points of intersection between these interdisciplinary studies and Job 28. First, if we liken Job’s earlier speeches to his speech record, Job 28 would reflect a new speech pattern that deviates from Job’s previous sentiments that God has targeted Job (6:4; 7:14, 20; 9:17–18; 12:4; 13:15, 27; 16:7, 11; 19:6–12;) and that there is no evil in Job from which he needs to depart (6:24; 9:21; 10:7; 13:23; 27:6).¹⁰⁴ Moreover, in chapters 29–31, which conclude Job’s speech record, Job presents himself as a defender of justice and righteousness (29:14–17), a supporter of the oppressed (30:24–25), and committed to moral integrity and societal justice (31:1–40). Thus, Job’s speech record throughout the book diverges from the views expressed in chapter 28, namely its concerns for wisdom’s accessibility through fearing God and departing from evil. Rather than confessing evil, Job has insisted on his innocence.

Second, we note that Job 28 exhibits a high degree of incongruity with the rest of his speeches, though not in the same technical sense used by Khattri, et al. The most explicit statement is found in verse 28.

The fear of אֱדָנִי, that is wisdom;
and turning from evil is understanding. (Job 28:28)

(Association for Computational Linguistics, 2015): 25–30, esp. 25; <https://aclanthology.org/W15-2905>.

103. Aditya Joshi, Vinita Sharma, and Pushpak Bhattacharyya, “Harnessing Context Incongruity for Sarcasm Detection,” *Proceedings of the 53rd Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics and the 7th International Joint Conference on Natural Language Processing (Short Papers)* (Association for Computational Linguistics, 2016): 757–62, esp. 758; <https://aclanthology.org/P15-2124.pdf>
104. Both in 7:20 and 14:16–17 there is reason to suggest that Job admits to his transgressions. Following GKC §159 h, in which the protasis of a conditional sentence may be introduced by the simple perfect when the apodosis is an interrogative clause, הֲטָאֵר is widely understood as the hypothetical “If I have sinned” since, as Habel (*Book of Job*, 165) notes, Job “contends throughout that he is quite innocent.” The issue in 14:16 is complicated by the fact that there are two polar opposite interpretive options for כִּי־עָתָה, either as divine torment or as divine mercy (Dhorme, *Book of Job*, 203). The point is not that Job is completely without transgression. Rather, he has committed no evil commensurate with the punishment he has received. In 14:16–17, he is hopeful that one day he would receive a fair accounting of his transgressions (Pope, *Job*, 111), rather than God taking note of every minor misstep to be martialed against Job at God’s discretion.

Besides seeing אֲדֹנִי as intrusive, many commentators also are uncomfortable with this sudden return to conventional wisdom, especially from the lips of Job. However, one might also see this verse as the height of sarcasm in an already overtly sarcastic poem. Both the narrator and Yahweh (1:1, 8; 2:3) attest to the fact that Job is a God-fearer (יִרֵא אֱלֹהִים) who has turned from evil (סָר מֵרָע). Yet Job has suffered tremendous evil (רָע) at the hand of this God (2:10). Job has persistently confronted God about the evil with which God has afflicted him. His declaration that it is now on Job to turn from evil (סֹר מֵרָע; 28:28) is incongruous with Job's earlier sentiments. Finally, it is interesting that sarcasm is indicative of informal speech among friends, which is precisely the situation found in Job 28. Whereas modern readers may have difficulty detecting the sarcastic nature of the chapter, Job's friends would have been on high alert.

It is not just because the poem in Job 28 stands in contrast to its surrounding chapters that his friends would have been attentive to sarcasm. Commentators note at least two other instances in the book where Job has responded sarcastically, or at least ironically, mockingly, or satirically. After the first cycle of speeches by his friends, Job retorts:

Indeed, you are the people,
and wisdom will die with you. (12:2)¹⁰⁵

Although there is some uncertainty on the meaning of עַם, “people” in 12:2a, Job's comment is incongruous with what he has espoused throughout the discourse. His mockery is amplified when he informs his friends that they could learn a thing or two from even the animals, birds, plants, and fish (12:7–8). He asks them rhetorically whether wisdom is only with the aged (12:12), suggesting once again that wisdom is lacking in his friends, before confessing that wisdom is with God (12:13), not them. Job certainly does not believe that access to wisdom would be lost when the friends perish.

Again, following Bildad's third speech, which concludes the friends' dialogue, Job responds:¹⁰⁶

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105. Brown, *Job*, 105; Crenshaw, *Reading Job*, 83; Dhorme, *Book of Job*, 168; Gordis, *Book of Job*, 136; Gray, *Book of Job*, 216; Greenstein, *Job*, 31; Hartley, *Book of Job*, 205; Janzen, *Job*, 102; Konkel, *Job*, 95; Leland Ryken, *A Complete Handbook of Literary Forms in the Bible* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2014), 180; Longman, *Job*, 199; O'Connor, *Job*, 35; Seow, *Job 1–21*, 621; L. Wilson, *Job*, 80.
106. There is considerable debate regarding the speaker in Job 26, which is part of the broader discussion on the textual transmission of Job 24–28. The debate is fueled, in part, by the use of second masculine singular pronouns in 26:2–4, suggesting either a shift in audience or speaker. Elsewhere, Job refers to his companions in the plural, suggesting that one of the friends, namely Bildad, is now addressing Job. If Job is the speaker, as the received text implies, either Job has turned his attention to one of the friends, perhaps responding directly to Bildad, or Job has directed his speech to God (see, e.g., 7:6), whose actions often coincide with those portrayed in

How¹⁰⁷ you have helped one lacking power!
 You have saved the arm that lacks strength!
 How you have counseled one lacking wisdom,
 and have made known abundant acumen.
 With whom have you uttered words,
 and whose breath has exhaled from you? (26:2–4)¹⁰⁸

For seven days and seven nights Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar sat silently with their friend, uttering not a word, “because they saw that his anguish was extreme” (2:13). But they could not contain their words. “Who can keep from speaking?” Eliphaz asked. And thus began the relentless barrage of advice. Job expressed his opinions about their counsel, calling them empty adages (13:12). He accused the friends of being “troubling comforters” (16:1) who have distressed and tormented him (19:2, 3) whose “windy words” are limitless (16:3) and have shattered him (19:2). Job has not been helped by his friends’ wisdom and counsel. He has been harassed by it. Job’s words in Job 26:2–3 are incongruous with his sentiments in the rest of the book.

The use of sarcasm in the Bible is also well noted, especially among the prophets, as in Elijah’s “Surely he is a god” (1 Kgs 18:27; NRSVue), Micaiah’s “Go up and triumph; the Lord will give it into the hand of the king” (1 Kgs 22:15b; NRSVue), and Isaiah’s and Jeremiah’s mockery of human-made idols (Isa 44:9–20; Jer 10:3b–10;). Jeremiah’s case is especially pertinent for the purposes of this discussion, though the text is fraught with redactional complexities, with some scholars defending Jeremianic authorship, and many more denying it.¹⁰⁹

Job 26:2–4. For a brief summary of the issues and interpretive options regarding the speaker in Job 26, see Clines, *Job* 21–37, 630.

107. In several locations in Job, the particles *מַה* and *מָה* – as with *מַה* in 26:2 – are best rendered as the interjection “how,” rather than the interrogative “what” (see, e.g., 6:25; 26:2, 3; 31:1; 35:3). In 26:2–3, some interpreters see *מַה* (26:2) and *מָה* (26:3) as interrogative markers, thus introducing a series of rhetorical questions. I follow Dhorme (*Book of Job*, 377) who treats both as interjections.
108. Andersen, *Job*, 216; Ballentine, *Job*, 386; Chase, *Job*, 190; Crenshaw, *Reading Job*, 118; Habel, *Book of Job*, 378; Hartley, *Book of Job*, 362; Janzen, *Job*, 177; O’Connor, *Job*, 61; Pope, *Job*, 190; L. Wilson, *Job*, 127. Clines (*Job* 21–37, 630) and Gordis (*Book of Job*, 286) consider these verses as Bildad’s ironic response to Job, rather than Job’s sarcastic response to Bildad.
109. For the commonly accepted view that Jer 10–16 was not original to Jeremiah, see, e.g., Bernhard Duhm, *Das Buch Jeremia*. Kurzer Hand-Commentar zum Alten Testament (Tübingen/ Leipzig: Mohr Siebeck, 1901); John Bright, *Jeremiah*. Anchor Bible 21 (Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1965); Wilhelm Rudolph, *Jeremia*. Handbuch zum Alten Testament (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 1965); Robert P. Carroll, *Jeremiah: A Commentary*. The Old Testament Library (Philadelphia, PA: Westminster, 1986). On the view that Jeremiah authored the material, see, e.g., Thomas W. Overholt, “The Falsehood of Idolatry: An Interpretation of Jer. X. 1–16,” *Journal of Theological Studies* 16 (1965): 1–12; Meshullam Margaliot, “Jeremiah X 1–16: A Re-examination,” *Vetus Testamentum* 30 (1980): 295–308.

The prophet begins with a set of prohibitions: “Do not learn the way of the nations,” and “do not be dismayed by the heavenly signs” (Jer 10:2a–b). These are followed by two causal clauses introduced by the particle כִּי: “for (כִּי) the nations are dismayed,” and “for (כִּי) the customs of the people are false” (Jer 10:2c–3a). The prophet then proceeds with a lengthy satire against the making of idols (Jer 10:3b–9).¹¹⁰ What is most striking as it relates to Job 28 is that the prophet’s satirical unit is introduced by the particle כִּי, which has traditionally been interpreted according to one of two options. Some treat כִּי as a causal particle, rendering it “for,” linking 10:3b with the previous prohibitions.¹¹¹ Others understand כִּי as introducing a form of direct speech, leaving it untranslated.¹¹² If the כִּי in 10:3b functions in the latter sense, then it provides an important point of intersection with Job 28 where we would see another example of a lengthy poem in a mocking, sarcastic tone that is introduced by the particle כִּי.

CONCLUSION

Job 28 continues to perplex interpreters. The chapter is introduced by the particle כִּי, even though there is nothing that logically precedes the chapter to warrant the particle’s use. Even though Job is the purported speaker in chapters 26–27 and 29–31, clearly identified by the formulaic speech introductions (26:1; 27:1; 29:1), chapter 28 stands in sharp contrast to these surrounding chapters. For these and other reasons, interpreters are reluctant to attribute the words of chapter 28 to Job; instead they prefer to ascribe this chapter to the author as a parenthetical insertion, to Elihu, or to an independent composition, among other possibilities.

110. On Jer 10:3–9 as satire, see, e.g., John A. Thompson, *The Book of Jeremiah*. New International Commentary of the Old Testament (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1980), 325; William McKane, *A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on Jeremiah in Two Volumes, Volume I: Introduction and Commentary on Jeremiah I–XXV*. International Critical Commentary (Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1986), 220; Peter C. Craigie, Page H. Kelley, and Joel F. Drinkard, Jr., *Jeremiah 1–25*. Word Biblical Commentary 26 (Dallas, TX: Word, 1991), 160; Terrence Fretheim, *Jeremiah*. Smyth & Helwys Bible Commentary (Macon, GA: Smyth & Helwys, 2002), 167; William L. Holladay (*Jeremiah 1: A Commentary on the Book of Jeremiah Chapters 1–25*. Hermeneia [Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1986], 328) detects a tone of mockery, while Jack R. Lundbom (*Jeremiah 1–20: A New Translation with Introduction and Commentary*. Anchor Bible 21A [New York: Doubleday, 1999], 584–91) sees both mockery and irony. On the view that Jer 10:3–9 amounts to sarcasm, see Ernest W. Nicholson, *The Book of the Prophet Jeremiah Chapters 1–25*. Cambridge Bible Commentary (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1973), 100.

111. ESV, HCSB, NASB, NEB, NET, NIV, NJPS; Pesh. ܟܝ; Tg.J. ארי; Vulg. *quia*.

112. CEB, NLT, NRSVue, LXX. There is a break in the fragment of 4QJerb at Jer 10:3, thus offering no witness from Qumran to the interpretation of כִּי; see Emmanuel Tov, “71. 4QJerb,” in *Qumran Cave 4, X: The Prophets*, ed. Eugene Ehrlich, et al. Discoveries in the Judean Desert X (Oxford: Clarendon, 1997), 171–76 + Plate XXIX.

In this essay I have attempted to propose another avenue of interpretation. Readers should, in fact, understand chapter 28 as Job's words, but not as Job's convictions. Rather than representing Job's opinions, Job 28 is incongruous with Job's sentiments elsewhere and might best be understood as sarcasm, a tactic Job has employed at least twice before in the book. In the first case, Job concludes the first cycle of speeches with a sarcastic retort, and in the second case, he responds to the third cycle of speeches sarcastically. Job has neither been convinced nor consoled by his friends' wisdom. They have not responded with sincerity to his requests, so he chooses not to reply with sincerity to their response. As Greenstein has argued, "Job makes use of the forms of wisdom in order to undermine it."¹¹³ Thus, the wisdom poem of Job 28 provides Job one final opportunity to issue a sarcastic rhetorical barb, aimed not just at the friends, but at the entire tradition they espouse.

113. Greenstein, "Proverbs and Popular Sayings," 147; See his fuller argument in Edward L. Greenstein, "חכמה בספר איוב - תחת סימן שאלה" in *Wisdom, Her Pillars are Seven: Studies in Biblical, Post-Biblical and Ancient Near Eastern Wisdom Literature, Proceedings of a Conference Held at Ben-Gurion University of the Negev, Be'er Sheva, 9 Shevat, 5763, 12 January 2003*, Be'er-Sheva 20, ed. S. Yona/V.A. Hurowitz. (Be'er Sheva: Ben-Gurion University of the Negev), 41–50.

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